THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA

CONFINED DIFFUSION OF NANOPARTICLES USING iSCAT MICROSCOPY

by

Martin Jasinski

A THESIS SUBMITTED IN PARTIAL FULFILLMENT OF
THE REQUIREMENTS FOR THE DEGREE OF

Master of Applied Science

in

(Engineering Physics)

THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA

Department of Physics

June 29, 2026

Abstract

Particle confinement allows extended measurements of suspended biomolecules and nanoparticles using optical microscopy as it keeps it within the field of view.

However, during confinement, the size-diffusivity relationship changes from that in bulk, where the correction factor is typically assumed without consideration of the occurring measurement conditions such as surface charges and the media.

In this work, we show that by combining interferometric scattering (iSCAT) microscopy with microfluidic nanoparticle confinement we can directly measure the positional distribution and depth-dependent diffusivity. We demonstrate how it depends on particle charge and media properties for both reference beads and lipid nanoparticles. Utilizing range-of-depth motion and in-plane diffusivity as complementary diameter estimates, we showcase how 3D particle tracking under confinement allows for nanoparticle diameter quantification in protein-containing media.

The ability to measure the effect of confined diffusivity improves accuracy in trajectory-based particle sizing in varying media, commonly found in cell biology and nanoparticle sizing.[3].

Contents

1 Introduction **5**

1.1 Movivation 5

1.2 Outline for Thesis 5

2 Brownian Motion **7**

2.1 Classical Description of Einstein's Brownian Motion 8

2.2 Langevin Dynamics 9

2.3 From Master Equation to Fokker-Planck 10

2.4 Confined Diffusion Processes 11

2.5 Electrostatic Potentials 12

2.6 Equilibrium Positional Distributions for Anomalous Confined Diffusion 13

2.7 Example: Polystyrene Bead 13

3 Interferometric Scattering Principles **15**

3.1 Electromagnetic Scattering of of Homogenous Spheres 16

3.2 Types of Microscopy 18

3.3 Scattering Microscopy 18

3.4 Interferometric Light Scattering (iSCAT) 19

3.5 Resolution limits of optical microscopy 20

4 In-Vivo Considerations **23**

4.1 why does this matter for biological applications 23

4.2 Examples of Brownian Motion in Biology 23

4.3 Brownian motion as a method for measurements of size in biology 23

4.4 survey of methods using in this field 23

4.5 how confinemen effects these measurements 23

4.6 Probing of surface interactions with these methods 23

5 Widefield backscattering iscat for SPT in 3d confinement tracking and analysis **25**

5.1 Questions 25

5.2 Rayleigh scattering of nanoparticles 25

5.2.1 Parameterization used in this thesis 25
5.3 Methods 25
5.3.1 Optical System 25
5.3.2 Convex-lens induced confinement 25
5.4 Results i guess 25
5.5 Discussion of Results 25

6 Conclusion **27**
6.1 Conclusion 27
6.2 Future outlook 27

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Movivation

- What is the major field i am in? - what are the biological questions - how are they typically slved

- problems with the current solutions

In much of nature, the idea of size scales is widely discussed and investigated. From a basic understanding of physics, one understands that the forces an object feels are directly linked to their mass, or volume and mass density. For example, we can easily understand what will happen to a basketball if we throw it up into the air, as we are sitting on planet earth. However, when we leave the familar size scale, such as having a basketball the size of planet earth, or the size of a gas molecule, our intuition begins to show its cracks.

In size regime of nanoparticles, that is between 20-100nm, many biological particles of utmost importance tend to reside. For instance, in cellular biology, proteins, vesicles, enzymes, and organelles fit between 4 nm to 10 µm. In this size regime, the forces which one feels largely differ from that of say a basketball. Inter-molecular forces between nearby molecules have a strong effect on particle postion, thermal kicks from atomic molecules induce a stochastic motion non-determininstically, and forces of hydrodynamic pressure induce frictions slowing the particle down. Thus, to have any quantitative understnandig we must try to

1.2 Outline for Thesis

- Chapter 1 is an introduction/background - Chpater 2 discusses application of Widefield iSCAT for SPT in the Rayleigh Regime - Conclusion

Chapter 2

Brownian Motion

In the scope of biological processes, there are many such examples involving the particles in the nano size regime. For example, viruses and vesicles are two examples of small molecules which have immense importance in the field. To investigate such systems, it is often the case that to maintain long measurements of the same particle, it is necessary to have some form of confinement. The full understanding of the behavior of these nanoparticles under confinement is thus important, and not complete.

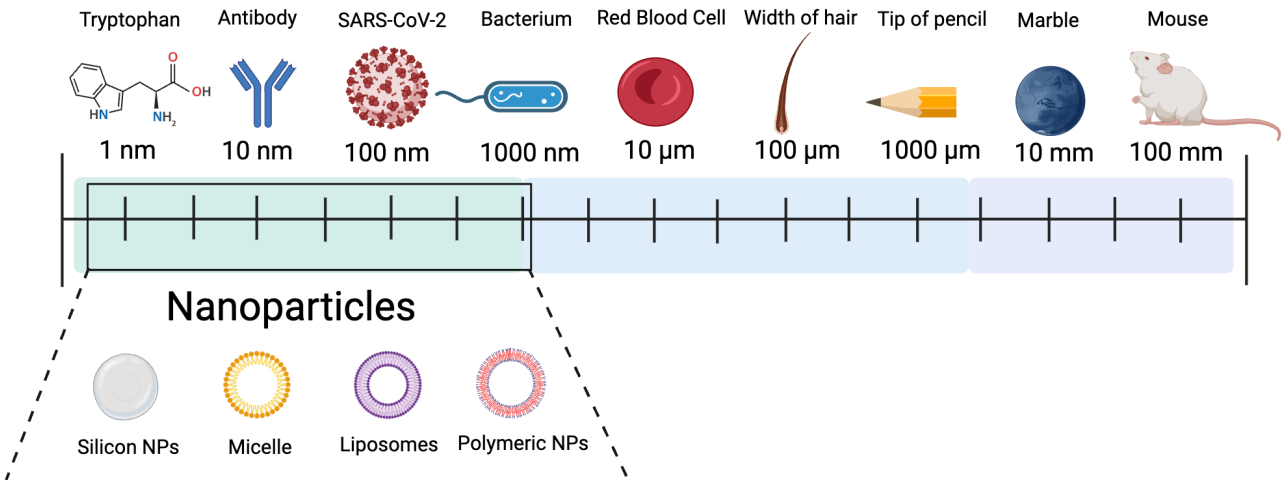


Figure 2.1: Size comparison of various nanoparticles. Nanoparticles are defined as particles where the largest dimension is at most 1000 nm.

Nanoparticles move around stochastically under the rules of brownian motion. To be able to measure the particle's characteristics, one can relate their motion and stochasticity to their properties. This chapter will discuss the phenomena of Brownian motion and how it relates to particle properties, environmental ion concentration, viscosity, hydrodynamic boundaries, and confinement.

In this chapter we discuss the process of Brownian motion and Diffusion-type processes. We

begin with Einstein's diffusion- equation argument and Langevin's stochastic equation of motion, and then show, through the Fokker-Planck, or Smoluchowski, formalism, that the two are equivalent descriptions of the same process. We next turn to diffusion under confinement, where hydrodynamic wall effects modify the mobility, and to the electrostatic (Debye-Huckel) potentials that govern particle-wall interactions in ionic solution.

2.1 Classical Description of Einstein's Brownian Motion

The physical phenomenon of diffusion can be rigorously described as the emergent behavior atomic particle undergoing random collisions with members of the surrounding environment. In the microscopic limit, where the radius of a particle is sufficiently small and thermal fluctuations dominate its dynamics, this erratic motion is referred to as Brownian motion, or more colloquially, a diffusive process [1].

The classical description of Brownian motion is concerned with how the molecular-kinetic theory of heat relates with microscopically visible size suspensions in liquid perform movements such that they can be viewed by a microscope. Einstein's argument is one of macroscopic motion. put simply, one can use a taylor series expansion over a general concentration function to show a natural property of the system. Using Einstein's original notation, suppose that $\phi(\Delta)$ denotes the probability to find a particle in some space Δ subject to the normalization

$$\int \phi(\Delta) d\Delta = 1 \tag{2.1}$$

Assume that the medium is isotropic such that ϕ is even, $\phi(\Delta) = \phi(-\Delta)$.

Let $f(x,t)$ denote some number of particles at the point x. Einstein takes a finite slice of this volume and equates it to a probability space;

$$f(x, t+\tau) = \int f(x+\Delta, t)\phi(\Delta) d\Delta \tag{2.2}$$

The argument here is that we can taylor expand both sides of this equation,

$$f(x, t+\tau) \approx f(x,t) + \tau \frac{\partial f(x,t)}{\partial t} \tag{2.3}$$

And in space;

$$f(x+\Delta, t) \approx f(x,t) + \Delta \frac{\partial f(x,t)}{\partial x} + \frac{\Delta^2}{2} \frac{\partial^2 f(x,t)}{\partial x^2} \tag{2.4}$$

Cancelling terms, one finds the classical diffusion equation to nearest order;

$$\frac{\partial f(x,t)}{\partial t} = \underbrace{\left[\frac{1}{\tau}\int \frac{\Delta^2}{2}\phi(\Delta)d\Delta\right]}_{D} \frac{\partial^2 f(x,t)}{\partial x^2} \tag{2.5}$$

Where we typically associate the diffusion coefficient with the second moment of the probability distribution

$$D = \frac{1}{\tau}\int \frac{\Delta^2}{2}\phi(\Delta)d\Delta \tag{2.6}$$

It can be shown through arguments of thermodynamics that the diffusion coefficient must abide by the rules of osmotic pressure, $\Pi = ck_bT$. Ideally have this laid out, i Don't know this off the top of my head. Notably, in the case of a spherical particle obeying Stoke's flow, we cite Einstein t find that the diffusion coefficient has the classical form'

$$D = \frac{k_bT}{\gamma_0}, \quad \gamma_0 = 6\pi\eta a \tag{2.7}$$

Where η is the fluid viscosity, and a is the spherical particle radius.

2.2 Langevin Dynamics

In typical experiments, such as that of Robert Brown's pollen molecules, the observed Brownian particle moves around in a fluid volume. The motion can be described by the bombardment of the surrounding particles around it. In particular, the system experiences a *random* force on it at every time step.

$$m\ddot{\vec{x}} = -\frac{\dot{\vec{x}}}{B} + \vec{F}(t) \tag{2.8}$$

where B is the mobility (drag term is $-\frac{\dot{\vec{x}}}{B}$), which is represented in a viscous friction term, and $\vec{F}(t)$ is a stochastic force term, meaning it takes a random value from some distribution f for every time step t. This model, although easily written, is quite profound and non-trivial to calculate. Here, $x(t)$ is a stochastic process, which has a unique realization for each realization of $F(t)$.

The statistical content of $\vec{F}(t)$ is fixed by the moments and auto-correlation. Notably, this relation is physically associated with the fluctuation-dissipation theory which relates the drag force to the random force. In Brownian motion, this takes the form

$$\langle\vec{F}(t)\rangle = 0, \quad \langle\vec{F}_i(t)\vec{F}_j(t')\rangle = \Gamma\delta_{ij}\delta(t-t') \tag{2.9}$$

Which stands in as delta-correlated noise, or that of a Wiener process. Notably, Γ is constrained by the equipartion theorem. This can be shown by calculating the velocity autocorrelation function

(VACF) and choosing the large t limit to agree with the equipartion theorem in 3-dimensions. This fixes the fluctuation constant to being

$$\Gamma = \frac{2k_bT}{B}. \tag{2.10}$$

One can take the ensemble average of this device, and notably, extract correlation information. Rewriting in terms of velocity, and assuming zero drift velocity one finds

$$m\vec{v} = -\frac{\vec{v}}{B} + \vec{A}(t), \quad \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} A(t)dt = 0. \tag{2.11}$$

This represents a linear differential equation with a solution hat defines the velocity autocorrelation function. This solution is

$$\langle \vec{v}(0) \cdot \vec{v}(t) \rangle = \frac{3k_bT}{m} e^{-t/(mB)}. \tag{2.12}$$

Furthermore, when one averages the product of the above equation with $\vec{x}$ and integrates over time, we find the following form of the mean-square displacement. Note that $\langle v^2 \rangle = \frac{3k_bT}{m}$, then the solutions of the position mean-squared displacement are written as

$$\begin{aligned} \langle x^2 \rangle &= 6k_bTmB^2 \left[\frac{t}{mB} - (1 - e^{-t/(mB)}) \right] \\ &\begin{cases} \xrightarrow{t \ll mB} \frac{3k_bTt^2}{m} & = \langle v^2 \rangle t^2 \\ \xrightarrow{t \gg mB} \frac{6k_bTmB}{m} t & = (6Bk_bT)t \end{cases} . \end{aligned} \tag{2.13}$$

Letting $D = Bk_bT$, we recover Einstein's relation with ease.

The unique advantage of the Langevin Formulation is that it is readily simulatable [4]. It can be shown that using an Euler-Maruyama scheme, the stochastic differential equation can be integrated over realizations of $F(t)$ using a random number generator, recovering the dynamics of an ideal brownian system Cite Pathria for this section.

2.3 From Master Equation to Fokker-Planck

To show that the two methods are equal, we can use the typical approach to equilibrium provided by the master equation. Suppose that $f(x,t)dx$ representation that he probability of an arbitrary particle in the ensemble has a displacement between x and $x + dx$. We find that if f is a probability distribution, we can write down the master equation, let W represent the traditional probability transition rate;

$$\frac{\partial f(x,t)}{\partial t} = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \left[f(x',t)W(x'|x) - f(x,t)W(x|x') \right] dx' \tag{2.14}$$

This structure is a statement about the probability of positional transitions, which is fundamentally equivalent to the Langevin equation[1] The right hand side can be expanded using the Kramer-Moyal expansion and truncated at second order, yielding the Fokker-Planck Equation.,

$$\frac{\partial f(x,t)}{\partial t} = -\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left[\sigma(x) f(x,t)\right] + \frac{1}{2}\frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2}\left[D(x) f(x,t)\right], \tag{2.15}$$

where the diffusive and drift terms are parameterized over the transition probalities,

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma(x) &= \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \xi W(x|\xi) d\xi \\ D(x) &= \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \xi^2 W(x|\xi) d\xi. \end{aligned} \tag{2.16}$$

In the case of zero drift, we can clearly see that this form equates to the diffusion equation of the Langevin formulation and the Eisensteinian formulation are the same. This important property allows us to investigate solutions and dynamics of the two systems interchangeably. In particular, relating expected results from simulatory behavior of Langevin problems.

2.4 Confined Diffusion Processes

The effect of diffusion near an interface on a nearby particle is quite particular. The effect on confinement can be first imagined as the effects from the fluid friction flow. Notably, the particle being immersed in fluid invites a stokes friction which effects the perpendicular and parallel flows. Hiding Faxén derived the relations in no-slip boundary conditions near a brownian particle;

$$\begin{aligned} \mu_{\parallel}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right) &\approx \mu_{\infty}\left[1 - \frac{9}{16}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right) + \frac{1}{8}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right)^3 - \frac{45}{256}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right)^4 - \frac{1}{16}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right)^5\right] \\ \mu_{\perp}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right) &\approx \mu_{\infty}\left[1 - \frac{9}{8}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{a}{h}\right)^3\right] \end{aligned} \tag{2.17}$$

In the case of a two-wall confinement, the form of the diffusion coefficient has a lot of depth in wealth. In application, it has been shown that the form of the Onseen drag in terms of mobility coefficients.

$$\gamma_2(z) \approx \gamma_0 + [\gamma_1(z) - \gamma_0] + [\gamma_1(H - z) - \gamma_0] \tag{2.18}$$

- Discuss Greens function alternative, but cite Dresfrene paper.

[1] Given a markovian system.

2.5 Electrostatic Potentials

A particle diffusing near a charged wall in an electrolyte will feel a screened electrostatic interaction. The Debye-Huckel theory is a description of the electromagnetic interactions between ions in a solution of ionic compounds. The potential in a field of ions must be solved in terms of electrostatics in a media. This is described by Poisson's equation

$$\nabla^2\Psi(\mathbf{r}) = -\frac{\rho(\mathbf{r})}{\varepsilon_0\varepsilon_r} \tag{2.19}$$

In a sea of ions, we must carefully define the charge density as it pertains to the system. In a general solution of ions, there will be j species of ions.

$$\nabla^2\Psi(\mathbf{r}) = -4\pi\frac{\rho_j(\mathbf{r})}{\varepsilon}$$

The charge distribution of a single ion concentration is essentially the density of the ionic positions. It would be tedious and unfeasible to count every ion's position exactly as we are assuming too many things. Rather, one can use a statistical ensemble of ions via a cannonical ensemble, which is a good approximation here.

$$\rho_i(\mathbf{r}) = \sum_i C_i e_0 Z_i \exp\left[-\beta Z_i e_0 \Psi(r)\right] \tag{2.20}$$

Here the energy of the system is defined as the potential energy scaled by the charge defined as $U = qV$. The full equation is known as the Poisson-Boltzmann equation, where $\Psi(\mathbf{r})$ is the potential for all space.

$$\nabla^2\Psi(\mathbf{r}) = -\frac{1}{\varepsilon_0\varepsilon_r}\sum_{i=1}^{\infty} C_i e_0 Z_i \exp\left[-\beta Z_i e_0 \Psi(r)\right] \tag{2.21}$$

There is a nice approximation we can make given that the potential of the solution is small. We linearize the exponential to first order here.

$$\begin{aligned}
\nabla^2\Psi(\mathbf{r}) &\approx -\frac{1}{\varepsilon_0\varepsilon_r}\sum_{i=1}^{\infty} C_i e_0 Z_i \left[1 - \beta Z_i e_0 \Psi(r)\right] \\
&= -\frac{1}{\varepsilon_0\varepsilon_r}\sum_{i=1}^{\infty} \left[C_i e_0 Z_i - \beta C_i Z_i^2 e_0^2 \Psi(r)\right] \\
&= -\sum_{i=1}^{\infty}\left[\frac{C_i e_0 Z_i}{\varepsilon_0\varepsilon_r} - \kappa^2\Psi(r)\right]
\end{aligned}$$

Where κ_i^2 is related to the debye-length, a unit of the electrostatic screening caused by the ionic interactions. The Debye length is defined as $\lambda_D = \kappa^{-1}$.

When the bulk solution is electroneutral, $\sum_i C_i Z_i = 0$, then the zeroth therm can cleanly drop out, leaving only the approximation;

$$\nabla^2 \Psi(\mathbf{r}) = \kappa^2 \Psi(\mathbf{r}), \quad \kappa_i^2 = \frac{\beta e_0^2}{\varepsilon_0 \varepsilon_r} \sum_i C_i Z_i^2. \tag{2.22}$$

This equation has an obvious solution which are the real exponentials;

$$\Psi(\mathbf{r}) = Ae^{-\kappa \mathbf{r}} + Be^{\kappa \mathbf{r}}. \tag{2.23}$$

2.6 Equilibrium Positional Distributions for Anomalous Confined Diffusion

In the case of interfaces, we have boundary conditions that case the particle to reflect off of the sides. Notably, the probability flux is set to 0. This implies that $\partial_x j = 0$ as well. Then, we need to solve the adjusted Fokker-Plank equation;

$$j = -\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left[D(x) f(x)\right] - \nabla V(x) f(x) \tag{2.24}$$

Using the forward or reverse Ito discretisation, we have that the general solution is;

$$f(x) = Ne^{H_0 + \int_0^x \frac{\nabla V(y)}{D(y)} dy} \tag{2.25}$$

This equation defines the equilibrium distribution of the brownian diffusion after a long time.

2.7 Example: Polystyrene Bead

To illustrate the wealth of information and form prior distributions for the confined diffusion model, we can simulate the diffusion process of a control molecule diffusing in a confined electrostatic environemnt.

The simulation scheme used here is the Euler-Maruyama scheme using a discrete time integration. The equations used to siumulate these particles are adapted from [4], and are listed below.

$$\begin{aligned} eq1 &= 1 \\ eq2 &= 1 \end{aligned} \tag{2.26}$$

We will simulate the priors of a Polystyrene bead diffusing with neutral charged walls, as well as those with varied levels of screening. In turn, we will be able to showcase the differnt cases of the known confined diffusion theory, as well as establishing prior curves for this work. In addition, the simulated curves will be compared to an effective theoretical model.

Run through a full calculation and simulation using Langevin Theory.

Chapter 3

Interferometric Scattering Principles

This section is devoted to the description of physical prinicples associated with light scattering techniques. These techniques are widely used in microscopy, as I have used them in measuring where my parteicles are. Scattering measurements are of interest as they allow for label-free imaging with a high signal to noise and high temporal resolution.

We begin with the basics of relating light to electromagnetsm, starting with the Maxwell and Helmholtz relations. We continue discussing the scattering of a various size range of spheres, which is the approximation we take in this thesis. We then discuss the various abberations and Considerations before introducting iSCAT microscopy. We tease the experimental apparatus used in tthis work and compare the method to other methods currently used in the field.

The photon is the fundamental quanta of the electric field as stated in QFT (cite). It has been shown that because of this, the field equations of light obey the fundamental principle that states

$$I = |\vec{E}(\vec{x}, t)|^2, \tag{3.1}$$

where $\vec{E}(\vec{x}, t)$ is defined as an optical field[1]. This principle relation allows us to form models using electromagnetic theory to map out how the optical fields behave.

This chapter will discuss the electromagnetic scattering theory of spheres, discussion of general optical scattering microscopy theory, then discuss the principle of iSCAT and its limitations.

[1]As opposed to an electric field, where $\vec{E}_{\text{optic}}(\vec{x}, t) = \sqrt{\varepsilon_0 n_m c/2}\vec{E}_{\text{elec}}(\vec{x}, t)$. The normalization constant affects how the fields relate to the measured light intensity [2]

3.1 Electromagnetic Scattering of of Homogenous Spheres

To As mentioned, we are tasked with getting the light from the scattered molecules. We approximate them as spheres. Thus, we need to solve the solutions of scattered light from spheres.

We start by using the wave equation for the Electric and Magnetic Fields

$$\nabla^2\vec{E} + k^2\vec{E} = 0, \quad \vec{H} = \frac{1}{i\omega\mu_0}\nabla \times \vec{E} \tag{3.2}$$

The solutions of these quantities will be harmonics of the laplacian in the coordinate basis that we choose. For isotropic scattering, the spherical basis is the one of choice. The solutions to this are known as the Vector Spherical Harmonics. Let ψ be a solution to the scalar wave equation

$$\nabla^2\psi + k^2\psi = 0 \tag{3.3}$$

, then we can form a generator of the general solution by taking the simplest form of solutions and summing all components. Citing Jackson, we find that the solution to this form is given by the seperable form;

$$\begin{aligned} \psi(r,\theta,\phi) &= \Phi(\phi)\Theta(\theta)R(r) \\ \Phi(\phi) &\in \{\cos(m\phi), \sin(m\phi)\} \\ \Theta(\theta) &= P_n^m(\cos\theta) \\ R(r) &\in \{j_n, y_n, j_n + iy_n, j_n - iy_n\} \end{aligned} \tag{3.4}$$

Where j_n, y_n are the spherical Bessel functions, and their complex additions are the hankel functions. Thus, the vector spherical harmonics are best described by seperating these solutions into even and odd solutions as their prefactor will be cos or sin respectively.

$$\begin{aligned} \vec{M}_{emn} = \vec{\nabla} \times (\vec{r}\psi_{emn}), \quad \vec{M}_{omn} = \vec{\nabla} \times (\vec{r}\psi_{omn}) \\ \vec{N}_{emn} = \frac{1}{k}\vec{\nabla} \times \vec{M}_{emn}, \quad \vec{N}_{omn} = \frac{1}{k}\vec{\nabla} \times \vec{M}_{omn} \end{aligned} \tag{3.5}$$

These are found in Eqns 4.17 to 4.20 in Bohren.

The incident light can be assumed to be polarized along the x axis without loss of generality. The general form of these equation will then be the sum of each of the spherical vector harmonics (SVH). subject to the energy conservation boundary condition

$$(\vec{E}_i + \vec{E}_s - \vec{E}_1) \times \hat{r} = (\vec{H}_i + \vec{H}_s - \vec{H}_1) \times \hat{r} = 0 \tag{3.6}$$

Citing Bohren, and stating that using orthongality of the SVHs, we have that the exact solution, which is known as the Mie Theory form of scattering off of a sphere, is given below;

Definition 1. *Mie Theory of scattering off of homogenous spheres*

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned}\vec{E}_i &= E_0 e^{ikr\cos\theta}\hat{x} \\ \vec{E}_s &= \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} E_n(ia_n \vec{N^{(1)}}_{e1n} - b_n \vec{M^{(1)}}_{o1n}) \\ \vec{E}_1 &= \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} E_n(ic_n \vec{M^{(1)}}_{o1n} - d_n \vec{N^{(1)}}_{e1n})\end{aligned}} \tag{3.7}$$

Since we are only interested in the scattered field, the constants that we care about are written below;

$$\begin{aligned}a_n &= \frac{m\Psi(mx)\Psi'(x) - \Psi(x)\Psi'(mx)}{m\Psi(mx)\xi'(x) - \xi(x)\Psi'(mx)} \\ b_n &= \frac{\Psi(mx)\Psi'(x) - m\Psi(x)\Psi'(mx)}{\Psi(mx)\xi'(x) - m\xi(x)\Psi'(mx)}\end{aligned} \tag{3.8}$$

where Ψ, ξ are the Riccatti-Bessel functions.

This needs to be properly defined. In the limit of a small particle from far away, we can mae some cancellations in these constants to simplify the work. Notably, the hankel function approches the limit of a spherical wave,

$$h_n(kr) \xrightarrow{kr\gg 1} (-i)^{n+1}\frac{e^{ikr}}{kr} \tag{3.9}$$

Im this regime, we have that $a_1 \approx \frac{-2i}{3}(ka)^3\frac{m^2-1}{m^2+2}$, and $b_1 \approx 0$. Thus for $n = 1$ we have that $\pi_1 = 1, \tau_1 = \cos\theta$, thus

$$\begin{aligned}M^{(3)} &\approx (-i)^{n+1}\frac{e^{ikr}}{kr}\left(\cos\phi\pi_n\hat{\theta} - \sin\phi\tau_n\hat{\phi}\right) \\ N^{(3)} &\approx (-i)^{n+1}\frac{e^{ikr}}{kr}\left(\cos\phi\pi_n\hat{\theta} - \sin\phi\tau_n\hat{\phi}\right)\end{aligned} \tag{3.10}$$

can be written in the Rayleigh approximation simply and in the form of the full scattering field;

$$\vec{E}_s = \frac{iE_0e^{ikr}}{kr}\left[\hat{\theta}\cos\phi\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}\frac{2n+1}{n(n+1)}(a_n\tau_n + b_n\pi_n) + \hat{\phi}\sin\phi\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}\frac{2n+1}{n(n+1)}(a_n\pi_n + b_n\tau_n)\right] \tag{3.11}$$

Spoiling the suprise, after plugging in the terms for $n = 1$ we have the following simplification;

$$\begin{aligned}\vec{E}_{s,\perp} &= \vec{E}_{i,\perp}\frac{k^2\alpha e^{ikr}}{r} \\ \vec{E}_{s,\parallel} &= \vec{E}_{i,\parallel}\frac{k^2\alpha e^{ikr}}{r}\cos\theta\end{aligned} \tag{3.12}$$

Then, to find the scattering intensity field, and noting $k = \frac{2\pi}{\lambda/n}$, we have the final scattering field in the Rayleigh regime;

$$\boxed{\vec{E}_s = \vec{E}_0 e^{ikr} \frac{\sqrt{8}\alpha\pi^2 n_m^2}{\lambda^2 r} \sqrt{1+\cos\theta}} \tag{3.13}$$

- Draw some of the iPSFs for Mie theory, from all angles. - manoharan theory and reparam of the main equation

- Set the stage, what do we need to solve, how are we going to do it - Solutions to the wave equation in spherical coordinates - Mie Theory – Examples of Mie spheres – What size range ? - RDG Theory – What size range ?

- Small comparison from far away, medium (mie), and small (RDG), atomic (too small)

3.2 Types of Microscopy

Dark field - microscopy where the background is not used widefield - microscopy where the full field of view is used holography - microscopy with a reference field (?)

3.3 Scattering Microscopy

As shown, the description of the scattered light from a sphere is full described by Eqn. 3.7, known as the Lorenz-Mie scattering theory (CITE). In the limit of particles on the order of the size of the wavelength of light, the Rayleigh model is an easier, equivalent method derived from Mie theory.

To collect the light, there have been three main schemes used in literature; forward, side, and backscattering micrpscopy schemes.

As shown in Fig. (reference PSF), the scattering distribution taken at different projections widely varies. In addition, the amount of light that gets collected in each of these regimes also varies.

do i go into the other models?

In the backscattering scheme, the light collected is the sum of the incident light and the scattered light.

$$I(x,y) = |\vec{E}_r + \vec{E}_s|^2 \tag{3.14}$$

given that the incident wave is known as a polarized plane wave, this equation can be rewritten for the scatterd light;

$$I = E_r E_r^* + E_s E_s^* + 2\Re[E_r E_s] \tag{3.15}$$

The incident field will be modulated by a scattering term, which is the Rayleigh scattering amplitude, S, as well as the reference term, R. Thus, the total intensity will be the sum of the scattering amplitude, reference amplitude, and the phase interference between the two fields;

$$I = |E_i|^2 \left[|R|^2 + |S|^2 + 2|R||S| \cos \Delta\varphi\right], \quad \Delta\varphi = \varphi_s \varphi_r \tag{3.16}$$

It should now be noted that the angle of image formation has not been specified. This is of importance as it allows to discuss the various methods of scattering microscopy without loss of generality between methods. Notably, the main difference is the angular content which is obtained from the various scattering models. In the case of spheres, this means using the various angular slices of the resultant scattered field. A full discussion of these comparisons can be found in (CITE).

...

- Olsén's thesis

3.4 Interferometric Light Scattering (iSCAT)

The key assumption in iSCAT is the relative magnitude of terms. The reference field is constant. The scattering term $R \approx k^4 \alpha^2 = \frac{V^2}{\lambda^4}$. Similarily, the inference term scales as the square root of this. Thus, the scattering term is dominated by the two fields, which we can ignore.

To accurately measure the positions, we can define the contrast metric, which relates the total field to that of a reference field;

$$\begin{aligned} C &= \frac{I - |E_r|^2}{|E_r|^2} \\ &= \frac{|S|^2 + 2|R||S| \cos \Delta\varphi}{|R|^2} \\ &\xrightarrow{|S| \ll |R|} \frac{2|S|}{|R|} \cos \Delta\varphi \end{aligned} \tag{3.17}$$

The phase of the interference consists of a sum of terms consisting of phases accumulated through the traversal of the scattered field. The total phase is dominated by the Gouy phase, which consists of phase accumulated when light is passed through a converging and diverging field, the defocus phase, which can be parameterized to a relative phase shift, as well as the phase accumulated phase difference, which is typical of a Michaelson-Interferomer type system.

Experimentally, this system is described in the set of schematics in Fig. 3.1.

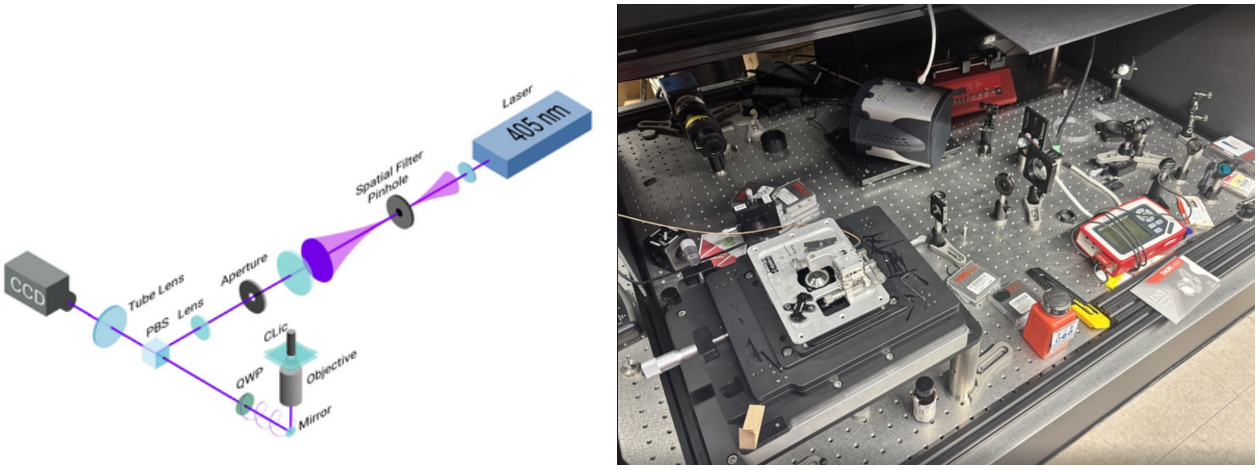


Figure 3.1: **Left**. iSCAT Schematic. **Right**. Image of physical system. A 405 nm laser is sent through a spatial filter, passes through an aperture. The beam is sent through a focusing lens which is reflected off a polarizing beam splitter, polarized through a QWP focused on the back plane of the objective. The scatterd light is then polarized again, passing through the polarizing beam splitter and is focused on the CMOS camera. The final image is collected via the CMOS and saved in binary format.

3.5 Resolution limits of optical microscopy

The last thing to touch upon is understanding how the image that is being enlarged arrives to the camera, which consists of discussion of optical aberrations.

As mentioned in the formulation for the electric field scatter we have that any optical field consists of a set of plane waves that construct and deconstruct to form a field. That is, the electric field lies in the basis of a fourier series of terms of complex exponentials. This fact allows one to describe the propagation of a wave in throughout z.

$$\vec{E}(x,y,z) = \iint_{\Omega} \vec{E}_0(k_x,k_y) e^{-i\left(xk_x+yk_y+\sqrt{k^2-k_x^2-k_y^2}\right)} dk_x dk_y, \quad \Omega = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x^2 \leq k^2\} \tag{3.18}$$

We have that the energy of the wave is fixed by the trigonometric relation of the transverse wave vectors. Notably, this is fixed by the relation $|k| = \frac{2\pi}{\lambda}$.

The propagated wave passes through an objective which can be approximated by a lens. Using the ABCD matrix formulation, we can find that to have a clear image, the imaging condition must be satisfied, that is

$$\frac{1}{z_1} + \frac{1}{z_2} = \frac{1}{f} \tag{3.19}$$

where z_1, z_2 are the positions of the observer and the object, and f is the focal distance of the lens. Thus, the magnification of the lens is defined as $M = z_2/z_1$. However, to understand the aberrations it is nessecary to have a field formulation of this problem. The simplest way to do this is described using linear optics theory.

Briefly, we define a pupil function $P(x, y)$ which is unitary if $r \leq R$, where R is the radius of lens. The point spread function of the object is then defined as a delta function through a two lens system. This is given by the fourier transform of the point source masked by the pupil function;

$$H(x, y) = \iint_{\Omega} P(x', y') e^{\frac{ik}{2}\left(\frac{1}{z_1} - \frac{1}{f_1} - \frac{1}{f_2} + \frac{1}{z_2}\right)\sqrt{x'^2 + y'^2}} e^{-\frac{ik}{z_2}(xx' + yy')} dx' dy' \tag{3.20}$$

Expanding this, one can use a zero-order Hankel transform to integrate over the radius and find that the point-spread function, H, is defined in terms of the NA and the magnification;

$$H(r, z) = \int_0^1 e^{-\frac{ik}{2}\frac{\mathrm{NA}^2}{n}\rho^2 z} J_0\left(\frac{k\mathrm{NA}}{M}\rho r\right) \rho d\rho \tag{3.21}$$

where ρ is the rescaled radial vector $\rho = r'/R$, $\mathrm{NA} = nR/f_1$, and $M = nf_2/f_1$.

In perfect focus, we have that $z = 0$, for $z \neq 0$ we have a defocusing aberration which is defined as the secondary exponential. For a point source, which is diffraction limited, we find that the following is the limit of the optical microscope;

$$H(r, 0) = \left|\frac{J_1(k\mathrm{NA}r)}{k\mathrm{NA}r}\right|^2 \tag{3.22}$$

We can solve that the minimum distance between the peak of the PSF and the minumum is solved by $k\mathrm{NA}r = x_0$ where x_0 is the first root of $J_1(x)$. This is classical known as the minimum transverse imaging criterion;

$$r_{\min} = 0.61\frac{\lambda}{\mathrm{NA}} \tag{3.23}$$

Similar results are found for the minimum axial imaging criterion by setting $r = 0$ and integrating.

$$z_{\min} = \frac{2\lambda n}{\mathrm{NA}^2} \tag{3.24}$$

At this point, we invite the fact that not all the light that scatters passes through teh lens. Specifically, the range of k_x and k_y are fundamentally limited by the wavelength. The resolution limit is λ/NA. In the case of scattering microscopy, this is not a large problem as the scatteirng pattern is much larger, hwoever, in the limit of two particle near each other, the spatial reoslution limit must be enforced.

discuss how we go from reality (focus plane) to image (image plane).

- sphereical abberations - guoy phase ...

- final kind of check

theortical 100 nm particle -¿ scattering field -¿ abberations

Chapter 4

In-Vivo Considerations

- Now that we more or less know how BM works, why is it important in cells?

4.1 why does this matter for biological applications

4.2 Examples of Brownian Motion in Biology

4.3 Brownian motion as a method for measurements of size in biology

4.4 survey of methods using in this field

- Optical Methods - Bulk: DLS, - Single Molecule: SPT, NTA, FCS,

4.5 how confinemen effects these measurements

- Literature on why these methods are lacking

4.6 Probing of surface interactions with these methods

Chapter 5

Widefield backscattering iscat for SPT in 3d confinement tracking and analysis

5.1 Questions

5.2 Rayleigh scattering of nanoparticles

5.2.1 Parameterization used in this thesis

5.3 Methods

5.3.1 Optical System

5.3.2 Convex-lens induced confinement

5.4 Results i guess

5.5 Discussion of Results

Chapter 6

Conclusion

6.1 Conclusion

6.2 Future outlook

Bibliography

[1] Robert Brown. "XXVII. *A brief account of microscopical observations made in the months of June, July and August* 1827, *on the particles contained in the pollen of plants; and on the general existence of active molecules in organic and inorganic bodies*". en. In: *The Philosophical Magazine* 4.21 (Sept. 1828), pp. 161–173. ISSN: 1941-5850, 1941-5869. DOI: 10.1080/14786442808674769. URL: https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/14786442808674769 (visited on 06/19/2026).

[2] Berenice García Rodríguez et al. "Optical label-free microscopy characterization of dielectric nanoparticles". en. In: *Nanoscale* 17.14 (2025), pp. 8336–8362. ISSN: 2040-3364, 2040-3372. DOI: 10.1039/D4NR03860F. URL: https://xlink.rsc.org/?DOI=D4NR03860F (visited on 06/24/2026).

[3] Albert Kamanzi et al. "Simultaneous, Single-Particle Measurements of Size and Loading Give Insights into the Structure of Drug-Delivery Nanoparticles". en. In: *ACS Nano* 15.12 (Dec. 2021), pp. 19244–19255. ISSN: 1936-0851, 1936-086X. DOI: 10.1021/acsnano.1c04862. URL: https://pubs.acs.org/doi/10.1021/acsnano.1c04862 (visited on 06/18/2026).

[4] Elodie Millan et al. *Numerical simulations of confined Brownian-yet-non-Gaussian motion.* en. arXiv:2210.15942 [cond-mat.stat-mech]. Mar. 2023. DOI: 10.48550/arXiv.2210.15942. URL: http://arxiv.org/abs/2210.15942 (visited on 06/18/2026).